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Tax bite looms if pot sales repealed

State, cities, towns have much to lose

By Bryan Hecht
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Tax revenue from recreational marijuana, one of the state's most highly taxed consumer products, could vanish if a November ballot question seeking to eliminate the industry succeeds.

Last year, weed taxes raised \$289 million for state government, the same as cigarettes — and nearly three times more than alcohol. Towns and cities, meanwhile, collected \$50 million. Combined, cannabis taxes have almost surpassed \$2 billion since pot shops opened eight years ago.

Pot taxes account for only around half a percent of Massachusetts' total tax revenues, but losing that money could spell trouble for some towns and state efforts, especially addiction services. Surging inflation and health care costs are choking government budgets, prompting many towns and cities to ask voters for property tax overrides this spring.

“Like with every revenue stream in the Commonwealth, if you lose out on that . . . [the budget] gets squeezed,” said Jessica Troe, deputy director of research at Massachusetts Budget & Pol-

TAXES, Page A7

Maine town still reeling after blast

By Sabrina Shankman
GLOBE STAFF

SEARSMONT, Maine — Amanda Boyington was making brownies in the back kitchen of Fraternity Village General Store when she overheard a snippet of talk.

Something about a fire? The words drifted in and out of her consciousness.

She kept working, preoccupied with one of the many tasks that come with owning the town's only general store.

But then the sirens started, and for the longest time, they didn't stop. Fire trucks, ambulances, and police vehicles screamed by, far more than are owned by this small, Midcoast Maine town roughly 100 miles northeast of Portland. That meant other towns were responding too. That meant something big.

Boyington would soon learn: a fire had started at Robbins Lumber, a fifth-generation, family-owned sawmill up the road, and the area's biggest employer. Volunteer firefighters — people with day jobs and outside lives having nothing to do with first response — had raced over to put out the blaze.

Then an explosion ripped through a silo.

Andrew Cross, a 27-year-old firefighter from Morrill, just a few miles north of Searsmont, died at the scene. At least 10 others were injured, many with severe burns requiring intensive

EXPLOSION, Page B4



PHOTOS BY DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

If you have the money, there's no limit to what you can do in the Seaport. From top, mini golf at Puttshack, cornhole on Cisco Beach, and driving in the F1 Arcade.

PLAYING FOR KEEPS IN THE SEAPORT

‘Competitive socializing’ is the name of the oh-so-pricey game

BETH TEITELL

How many boozy adult playgrounds can one neighborhood take? In the Seaport, the question is gaining urgency as yet another “competitive socializing” venue opens.

You could spend an entire day doing a Seaport crawl — except instead of bars, you'd hopscotch from competitive socializing venue to competitive socializing venue, from Flight Club to Spin to F1 Arcade to Puttshack to Ballers to 5 Iron Golf, to Kings, doing shots with your groomsmen, sharing truffle fries with Zoom colleagues, dropping hundreds of dollars as you play mini golf, simulator golf, pickleball, padel, ping pong, bowl a game, drive a racing car, throw a dart, lick hot honey ricotta off your fingers, pose with a cold brew espresso martini, check your ex's Insta, until finally — when you long for nothing so much as an es-

cape room — you Uber 10 feet to Remedy Place, a “social wellness club,” and drop \$349 to have your VO2 Max assessed.

I was drawn to the Seaport by the pull of the sea, or maybe it was the pull of competitive socializing, or “eatertainment,” as it's sometimes called, a category that's growing so fast that Cushman & Wakefield, the global commercial real estate firm, says it “cannot be ignored.”

Competitive socializing “concepts,” the firm reported in 2023, grew 386 percent in just a couple of years.

As I crossed over the Fort Point Channel into the Seaport on a recent day, I engaged my core muscles and changed into my sneakerinas, for I knew that where I was going, the babies have good hair, the dogs have veneers, and though I would be invisible, the gaze would still be unfor-

SEAPORT, Page A6

World Cup fever still running low in state

Watch parties in jeopardy, train ticket sales lagging, hotels not fully booked

By Chris Serres and Michael Silverman
GLOBE STAFF

Hotel bookings are well below expectations and sales of commuter-rail train tickets to the games at Gillette Stadium are also lagging. Meanwhile, city and state officials are clashing over security and traffic plans to help get those fans to Foxborough on time and safely.

These are yet more signs that with just a few weeks before the World Cup kicks off, interest in and local plans for Boston's part of the world's largest sporting event continue to be underwhelming.

And add to that the concerns of cities and towns that FIFA, soccer's global governing body, is so far behind in granting permission for community watch parties that they are on the verge of scratching those plans all together.

“To say we're frustrated is an understatement,” said Sandhya Iyer, director of economic development and tourism for Lexington, which had hoped to host World Cup fan parties on the lawn of the town's visitors center but is still waiting on a permit from FIFA.

Iyer is so frustrated by the delay that she recently placed a handmade sign on the site that says, “Give Us a License to Celebrate Soccer.”

WORLD CUP, Page A7

As paths cross again, finding new life

YVONNE ABRAHAM

This is the story of an earnest English teacher and the precocious 10-year-old who hated him.

It's about how that girl grew up to pull off several lifetimes' worth of death-defying feats.

And how, a few weeks ago, she performed the most spectacular one of all.

More than 40 years after Montana Miller left her fifth-grade nemesis behind, she gave him a gift that she hoped would save his life.

We'll get to that, but let's start in 1980, at The Bromfield School in Harvard, where Miller had what she considered the extreme misfortune of getting stuck in Mr. Mitchell Grosky's reading class.

She bristled at the books Grosky assigned, too silly and slow and easy. Miller's parents had started the local newspaper, the Harvard Post, and fed her love of reading and writing far beyond her years. Grosky bored her. She constantly challenged him in the classroom.

“I absolutely could not stand him,” said Miller, now 55. “It was a battle of the minds, a battle of wills.”

ABRAHAM, Page A6



MARIO MAURO

Montana Miller was there for her former teacher Mitchell Grosky.

Imperfect opportunity

Friday: A little cool.
High 58-63. Low 49-54.

Saturday: More clouds.
High 59-64. Low 49-54.

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

The City of Boston paid \$11 million to a man who spent nearly 40 years in prison before a court vacated his conviction. **B1.**

The man accused of randomly shooting motorists on Memorial Drive was declared a danger to society during a court hearing. **B1.**

The Massachusetts Convention Center Authority is reviving efforts to expand the Menino Convention & Exhibition Center in South Boston. **B5.**

Kyle Busch, who won more races than anyone across NASCAR's three national series, died at 41. He had been hospitalized with an illness. **C5.**

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